

leaving two trapped in it.

"They're the Merchant Prince's poachers," Vilde points out. "We saw them, at the Temple of Savras. They were hunting Arthur."

"My companion has the battle settled," Raphael says as he circles up with Arthur Cimber. "Please, let us talk."

A VETERAN OF THE WAR OF AXE AND VINE

The Party gathers around Arthur Cimber and Dragonbait as Raphael shares their experiences with Yandala, who had claimed that Arthur Cimber was her father.

"Well, where was she from?"

The Party has no clue. They realize that, despite spending so much time with Yandala, they know frighteningly little.

"I think maybe Ryoko," Wukong offers, remembering the time she broke down at the campfire while talking about her brother. The paladin casts *Zone of Truth*, wanting to be sure that Arthur Cimber is telling the truth.

"I've never been there," Arthur replies. "And I don't know this... Yandala. Maybe she is my kid, I don't know. I was from the land you know as the Victorian Empire, but long before the Concord and long before the Sundering War. I've lived a long life."

"And how did you live so long?" Hazel asked.

Arthur Cimber smiles shyly. "I'm afraid that's something I have to keep close to my chest." Recognizing that Hazel has the *Grimoire of Saleander* on her, he asks "You're a follower of Saleander, aren't you?"

"You were on the opposite side," Raphael remembers. "During the War of Axe and Vine."

Arthur nods. "Yes, I was. But I harbour no hostility against her followers. What her trickster spirits did centuries ago are not the crimes of her followers now. Besides, I have bigger problems. The love of my life is encased in resin and frozen in time." He explains that many years ago, during the War, Ras Nsi and Jarlan the Irresponsible constructed a Death Rider Engine to animate the dead, marshalling an army that does not need food and drink so as to destroy Raya. However, this was a massive violation against Ubtao's principles, and so Alisandra and himself went to stop it.

"During the battle, someone struck the engine," Arthur explained. "Even though we were victorious, the Death Rider Engine began melting down. It released wave upon wave of dangerous necromantic energy."



“Alisandra invoked Ubtao’s magic and sealed both herself and the Engine in amber,” He explains. “At the Heart of Ubtao. She has since remained frozen there, in time. I went to Port M’Kaze to try and petition the Ytepka Society to help, but they rejected me. That’s when we met.” Arthur finished.

“Yes indeed,” Dragonbait continues. The saurial paladin explains that he had come here for revenge. Having sought Nanny Pu’pu’s help for information with tracking down the royalty of Omu, he was tricked by the Hag into giving her “a moment of his time.” She had abused this moment, seizing it to make the paladin kill his own brother. Seeking vengeance against the Hag, Dragonbait agrees to help free Alisandra, provided that Arthur helps to avenge his brother.

TRADING WITH DRAGONBAIT

Item	Price
Crimson Rapier	3000 gp
Zephyr	1500 gp
Flame Tongue Glaive	700 gp

The Party trades with Dragonbait, who shares some of the weapons he’s carrying. Raphael elects to buy the *Crimson Rapier*. Vilde tosses him the gold, on the condition that the sorcerer owes her one.

Salazar shares that he is running low on supplies needed to learn new spells. “I need gold ink,” He explains, “And some experimental material components for practicing to learn new spells.” Tabulating his requirements, he asks Vilde for 1,050 gold pieces.

“Well, we can’t buy anything here anyway,” The elf points out. “Ask from me when we’re back in civilisation.”

The Party also scans Nanny Po’po’s body and residence, searching for anything of value. Entering the hag’s hut, they see Duo softly licking up the spilled contents from Vilde’s potion.

INTELLIGENCE (INVESTIGATION) CHECK
On a failed DC 15 check, the Party finds nothing of value.

“Alright, Duo, let’s go,” Hazel says. She sees Duo’s pupils dilate at the effect of the potion; the cleric recognizes that Duo is now under the effects of the *Bless* spell.

Raphael and Salazar investigates his “Potion of Eyes.” The wizard sinks a flask in to inspect the clear liquid. He recommends not drinking the potion, suggesting that there might be unintended side effects.

“Well, no harm keeping it,” Raphael pockets the flask.

Outside, Arthur shares that he and Dragonbait “must be on their way.” They plan to head to the Heart of Ubtao and rest up before continuing on their journey to free Alisandra. They bid the Party farewell as they head out of Zarula.

As the Party discusses what to do next, Salazar and Hazel realize that Elizabeth Shadowmantle is Gemini, and also coincidentally at the Heart. Salazar reminds everybody that Elizabeth is the lich from the Tale of the Twins, and that “they should have warned Arthur”, lest a fight breaks out and he kills her.

Exhausted from their long day, the Party decides to rest first, clear the crypt that Vilde had unlocked by solving the riddle before Nanny Po’po, then head to the Heart the next day.

The Party sets up their new Commanders’ Tent out in the open fields outside Nanny Po’po’s house and begin winding down.

BIRTHRIGHTS

As all of you snuggle by the fire in your new tent, Vilde, Hazel and Wang Lei all of you inexplicably feel a bit... morose. Daydreams, wishful thinking, choices in your past where you feel you were lying to yourself start to bubble up in the fire.

“So,” Vilde starts. “What do you all think life is?”

Salazar stares longingly into the fire and mutters under his breath: “Love, lost.”

“A never-ending mission,” Raphael says.

“Okay,” Wang Lei says. “I don’t know.” The group bursts into laughter; Wang Lei smiles and says, “I really don’t. I’m at a crossroads myself.”

Vilde turns to Hazel. “What about you?”

“It’s about feeling the wind, in between your fingers,” Hazel says. “And the mud on your feet.”

Vilde inspects the harregon’s mud-caked feet, and declares, “Life, is B2D.”

A chorus of confused ‘huhs’ go up. “Birth to death,” Vilde explains. “And what’s the letter in between? C. C, is for the choices we’ve made. We have all made choices to be here.” The elf surveys the group. “When I was young, I was very sickly. I couldn’t go to school much; it was, like, 10 days a year, kinda vibe. And it was all because of my congenital heart disease.”

The group falls silent.

“I had a engorged heart,” Vilde continues. “None of the elven physicians and clerics could figure out how to heal



me. All I wanted was to travel the world, and I could not even leave the bed. Until, one day, Mum managed to find an experimental drug of some kind. It was risky, but I decided to take it. It cured me, and finally enabled me to attend school and travel out of Nike and see the world. It was the best decisions I ever made.”

She looks around the fire as everyone is listening intently. “We’ve all made different choices to get here. And, as we all know, I volunteered and took over my mother to come here on this Expedition. That is another choice I am glad to have made.”

“I am also thankful of the choices you’ve made, m’lady,” Mason squeezes the rogue and kisses the side of Vilde’s head.

Hazel stares pensively into the fire as she shares her own thoughts. “I have also been thinking about my own path,” the cleric says. “As you all know, I found the *Grimoire of Saleander* beside the grave of my pet. I believe that he lives on inside me.” As she speaks, Brownie the dog comes up and begins licking the harregon. “I have been thinking. Was the book meant for me? I am the only believer I have met thus far. And, when I found it, the *Grimoire* not only had no dust and grime on it, but it was shimmering with power. Was I chosen? Why? I am just a small rabbit. The eldest daughter of a small guide in the forest. What led me here?”

The harregon’s reflections pass silently over the campfire. “I’ve been dreaming,” She shares. “A goddess covered with vines. She has no head, and she is covered in butterflies. The dreams are always the same. The vines coil around me and constrict me but I don’t feel fear. I feel ecstasy.”

WISDOM (PERSUASION) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Mason is intrigued by these dreams.

WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Hazel sees Thaisha’s pain, but do not recognize the cause.

“It’s been a heavy discussion tonight,” Wang Lei adds. “But I find it incredibly relatable. I have also been reflecting on my own journey thus far. After this expedition, I am meant to take over my foster father as the Castellan of Summer’s Outpost in the Russett Jungle. I have been brought up to do that ever since I was young. But, the Expedition has opened my eyes. I am now realizing that I came from a very small world. There were many threats that we had faced, and I could have died in any one of the encounters we had. I have been humbled, and the near-death encounters have really made me start reflecting on what is truly important to me.”

Soft murmurs of agreement go up in the group. "I'm still young," Wang Lei says as he echoes Vilde's sentiment. "Maybe I should be out exploring the world instead, training myself to be in a position of power to defend myself and the people that I love. The world is much bigger than we know." The paladin pauses as he says this, unsure whether or not he should share it, but relenting nonetheless.

"And I've been told that my foster father might be in some trouble," Wang Lei confesses. "I need to head back there urgently, but there are important things to do here."

On that note, the Party finishes their fried potatoes (drizzled with a creamy spicy sauce) as they head off to bed.

UNDER THE INFLUENCE

Vilde. As you awake for your watch, you see Mason standing over you. His eyes are jet black, as he glowers down at you. In his hand, held so tightly his knuckles are white, is *Blackrazor*.

Faster than most, Vilde rolls out of bed and picks up her *Frost Brand Scimitar*. "What's up, Mason? What are you doing in my room?"

CHARISMA (PERSUASION) CHECK

On a successful DC 25 check, Vilde breaks the spell over Mason.

Mason drops *Blackrazor*. He is confused at being in Vilde's room, and after learning about what happened is appalled at what he was about to do. He says that "the sword has been speaking to him", and has been telling him that "he is weak and that he can be stronger if he chooses to bond with the blade". Vilde realizes that the cursed greatsword has a mind of its own, and if *Blackrazor* is not dealt with it will continue to be a problem.

"I'm sorry you had to see me like this, m'lady," He says. "I've never been the strongest. Even when I was a kid. My sister Mayali was always stronger and faster than me. When the Gallows Choir came to recruit us, she beat me at the obstacle course."

As he speaks, Vilde, your Locket of the Stolen Heart glows. His memories start to pour into yours: you see him with his sister and several other kids who cannot be older than twelve.

The kids stand at attention in front of a gruff looking man; the children are all clad in armour meant for much bigger people than them. The man barks several commands, and sends all of them racing into an obstacle course of some kind.

WISDOM (PERCEPTION) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Vilde finds their parents - they are the smallest, hungriest, most gaunt looking pair. Vilde realizes that they, unlike the other parents gathered here, have given all their food to Mason and Mayali, so that they might succeed.

STRENGTH (ATHLETICS) CHECK

On a DC 15 check, Mason is recruited by the Gallows Choir.

Mayali tears ahead, past the pack of rushing children. Despite falling, Mason screams and charges past the rest, finishing second.

"We'll take them both," He says to the crowd of parents watching. He turns to a fellow soldier, and says "can somebody get these beggars out of here?"

The man drops a sack of gold into the parents' hands. "Tomorrow, dawn. Bring them both to the Yawning Portal."

The vision fades as Mason's face returns. His eyes shimmer softly, as he blinks and looks away. "I'm sorry. I- I didn't know it could do that. I think about that day a lot. It was the last day I saw my parents."

"Do you think your locket could do that too?" Mason asks.

"Yeah maybe," Vilde lies. "If I was as emotional." She hugs him, and sends him back to sleep. "Go rest, please."

"And what about the greatsword?" Mason asks.

"I'll deal with it," Vilde assures. "Don't worry."

Vilde, picking up the greatsword with her pinkies like the weapon is radioactive, heads to Raphael's room. "Bro... we have a problem."

In the middle of washing his face to prepare for their watch, Raphael turns to find Vilde with *Blackrazor*. She explains what happened, and shares her suspicion at what's going on.

Hazel and Wang Lei, perplexed that those who are supposed to take over their sentry duty are not here yet, abandons their post to come up and find Raphael and Vilde discussing about the sword.

"I think the sword is compelling us to take a life," Raphael intuits. "It is urging us to kill, to feed it maybe."

"Well, we should destroy it," Vilde says.

"Got to throw it in the fires of Mount Doom,' Hazel says, rubbing the sleep in her eyes.

Wang Lei thinks back to his time in the Guard and remembers that powerful weapons can only be unmade in the same place they were made. To destroy Blackrazor, it is likely they will need to find its point of origin and then destroy it there.

"Maybe we should just throw it in the well out there," Hazel suggests, fighting her exhaustion. "It's as good a place as any."

The group devolves into an argument, with Raphael and Wang Lei saying that it is a bad idea. Resolving to come up with a solution tomorrow, Hazel and Wang Lei head off to bed while Raphael and Vilde takes up watch.

A SUBTLE SLEEP SPELL

As Raphael and Vilde take up watch duties, they stand guard with *Blackrazor*. They make small talk to pass time, before a silence falls over them both. Vilde works on her book *Stick 'Em with The Pointy End*, while the sorcerer continues inspecting the cursed blade.

WISDOM SAVING THROW

On a failed DC 14 check, Raphael is struck with a *Sleep* spell.

Raphael's eyes shut as he falls asleep. Vilde feels a spell pass over her, but she resists the *Hold Person*. She starts smacking Raphael, but fails to wake him.

"Guys! Come down! There's something happening!"

Wang Lei, Hazel, Wukong, Salazar, Thaisha, Ayo and Mason all rush downstairs. The exhausted cleric asks "what is it now?"

"Someone was casting spells here," Vilde protests. "Raphael, he's knocked out."

"Are you sure he wasn't just tired?" Hazel asks. The cleric walks up to Raphael and tries to wake him. She succeeds.

"Uh, sorry," Raphael says. "Must have dozed off."

Salazar casts *Detect Magic*. "No, she's right," he confirms. "There was a *Sleep* spell. And it didn't come from outside the tent. It came from inside."

Wang Lei asks if maybe *Blackrazor* did it. He shares the previous conversation the Party had regarding the cursed blade.

Salazar and Raphael both agree that the greatsword does not have the ability to cast *Sleep*. With no further information, the Party elects to head back to rest.

Salazar takes over Raphael's watch. As he keeps watch with Vilde, he shares that "there is a whole lot of conjuration magic in the tent, which is normal, but there is some illusory magic that should not be present." Salazar and Vilde then go room by room to try and identify the source of the illusory magic, but only see Wang Lei tossing and turning in his room.

THE CHILD'S WISH

Wang Lei. You find yourself in a dark stone chamber. There is no light source in the room, except for an enormous crystal cylinder held in place by three adamantine legs. In the glowing blue liquid, ghosts swirl as soft, otherworldly screams ring out.

The Child appears behind you. "So, now we know. The hags are vulnerable to Radiant damage. Good. Now, my warrior. Acererak has me imprisoned in the Tomb of Annihilation. Come. Free me."

Tired from the shenanigans of the long day, Wang Lei agrees. The Child asks if he wants anything in return, but the paladin shrugs.

"What I want, you can't give me," He says. "Now, please. Just let me rest."

The Child relents, letting the exhausted paladin get some rest.

CRYPT OF THE LAST KING

The Party awakes after the eventful night. After some quick discussion, they agree to check out the nearby ruins Vilde unearthed before heading off to the Heart to find Arthur Cimper.

Heading back to the crumbling statue, all of you enter the ruins. Stone stairs descend into a dark, 40-foot long room. Along the walls of the hall, there are stone shelves filled with dusty scrolls. You light your torches and see a closed double door made of stone standing at the far end, on the right side of the room.

Seeing that the door is locked, Vilde steps up and tries to pick the lock. She easily unlocks the door, letting Wang Lei and Wukong take point.

The room is dominated by a stony sarcophagus with an inscription caved into it. To your right, three coffins reside in wall recesses.

Salazar primes a *Fire Bolt* as something phases into him. The wizard turns around and throws the blast at Raphael.

A wall of tentacles erupt from the ground, shielding the sorcerer. Vilde fires her *Web* from the gauntlet, pinning Salazar against the wall.

"What are you doing?" Vilde demands.

Salazar sticks his tongue out and growls in response.

"It's ghosts!" Mason declared. He draws his blade, pointing it at Salazar and watching him closely. Wukong walks up to the restrained wizard and starts muttering a prayer to Buddha to try and expel the ghost possessing the wizard.

Wang Lei sees something incorporeal phase out of the coffins and inspects the wall. Surmising that the ghost must have been residing in the coffins, he charges up his mace with thunderous energy and slams it into the coffin, sending splintering wood all over the place. He strikes at the second coffin in the middle, but does not even crack it.

Ayo nocks an arrow, aiming it at Salazar. Seeing Wang Lei's success, Hazel decides to follow. She casts *Produce Flame*, and sends it flying towards the middle coffin, setting it ablaze.

Wang Lei fills a chill touch as one of the ghosts tries to enter his body. Stumbling backwards, smoke start to appear from the Teddy Bear as the ghost is ejected.

"What the hell is happening?" Salazar screams. Realizing that the wizard is awakened, Vilde sends her *Dagger* flying, striking a weak point in the coffin beside Salazar and collapsing it. She swings at the ejaculated ghost with her scimitar, drawing screams of pain.

"Okay, enough," The sorcerer declares. Charging up a *Sorcerous Burst*, Raphael fires a powerful blast into the burning coffin and destroys it, dissipating the last ghost.

Having secured the crypt, the Party fans out and starts investigating the place. Vilde and Wang Lei unlock the sarcophagus, unearthing a *Staff of Flowers*.

Hazel heads back to the corridor, reading by torchlight the inscribed history of Zarula. She learns that Zarula was once the seat of a small kingdom. Situated high above the treeline of the wet Aldani Basin, the Zarulans relied mostly on rock for infrastructure rather than wood or clay. Over its years of existence, Zarula had a number of mines that became abandoned following the

slave uprisings in Omu, the city that would one day become Port M'Kaze. With no way of generating income, the King of Zarula pledged fealty to the Queen of Omu; Zarulan trade delegations would trade minerals, metals, and herbs in exchange for food, military aid and slaves. However, following the arrival of a certain 'witch doctor,' Zarula's population began dwindling at a rapid pace, prompting the people to bury King Mbala here in the crypt to appease the god Ubtao.

Returning back to the Crypt, Vilde and Wang Lei tell Hazel that they did not find much, but only the *Staff of Flowers*. The cleric is elated and takes the staff. The Party then has the ingenious idea of sealing *Blackrazor* here.

Placing *Blackrazor* in the crypt, Vilde gets to work locking the blade away. They also lock the outer door to ensure no one can break in before leaving for the Heart.

THE HEART OF THE WILDS

A massive chunk of earth and rock, torn from the ground, drifts over the Aldani basin, over two hundred feet above the water's surface. A petrified tree towers above the stone, with its stone roots protruding from the bottom. Between the shape of the rock and the branching of the tree's limbs, it creates the impression of a gigantic stone heart hanging in the sky. The impression is only made more gruesome by the red liquid dripping from the roots.

You see a cave mouth in the side of the slowly rotating "heart," and a staircase winding from the cave up to the flattened top where the petrified tree stands. The staircase definitely is not natural; it was carved with tools into the rock.



In the cave, you see a female elf waving at all of you from high up. Her voice carries over all that distance, appearing in your minds: “Oh, hello, fine travellers! I am Elizabeth. What are you doing here in the jungle?”

Vilde explains that they are friends with Dead-Eye Demodus, prompting Elizabeth to cast *Arcane Gate*. As a shimmering purple doorway appears in front of all of them, Elizabeth invites them up, but requests that only “the key members come up, as her house has not much space.”

Acquiescing to her request, the Party leaves behind Ayo, Mason, Princess and Duo.

Passing through the shimmering doorway, you see that this cave is musty and dimly lit by daylight filtering through the petrified tree trunk above. Everything in here has an orangish hue. At the center of the room, a pool of dirty rain water has collected, between natural pillars formed by the roots of the petrified tree. Three tall bookcases stand against the wall to the right of the cave entrance. A desk and several wooden crates stand against the left-hand wall. Opposite the entrance are two open doorways into smaller chambers, and between them, a large iron cage.

“If you’re working with Deadeye, then you must also be on the hunt for the Devourer,” Elizabeth starts. “Have you any luck in identifying its location?”

CHARISMA (DECEPTION) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Vilde lies to Elizabeth.

“No, we’re still looking for it,” Vilde explains. “Have you any luck?”

Elizabeth shakes her head and admits her defeat. “We haven’t. The Devourer has been our sole purpose here; that’s why we took up several high points around the continent to try and locate it, but to no avail so far. How has Dead-Eye fared?”

Salazar reports Dead-Eye’s death at the hands of the False Hydra, prompting a look of disappointment from Elizabeth. She laments how the wizard and his expedition had been particularly helpful, primarily because they were united in their goal of not destroying the Devourer, but studying its unique magical capabilities.

WISDOM (PERCEPTION) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Hazel spots drops of blood by the cage.



“Oh, don’t mind that,” Elizabeth explains. “That’s from the chickens I was keeping for food. Now, with Dead-Eye gone, I was hoping to be able to recruit more people to help get eyes out there to look for the Devourer. Can we count on you? I would pay handsomely.” She produces a sack of gold coins, which Hazel happily accepts.

“Thank you so much for your help,” Elizabeth says. “Now, if there’s any assistance or help you need, please, feel free to ask. Rest up here if you need to. I extend my hospitality to you brave adventurers.” The Party thank her for her hospitality.

LADY IN CRUEL CONFINEMENT

Hazel takes the opportunity to head out the cave and up the stairs, visiting the petrified tree.

Hazel. You are standing in front of the Tree. The towering oak stares down at you. Through gaps in the bark, you can see, trapped in orange amber, is a beautiful elf with her hands outstretched. Behind her, you see a complicated machine of some kind.

As you step up, preparing to cast *Speak with Plants*, you feel your backpack shake violently. The *Grimoire of Saleander* flies out from the backpack and lands in your hands, flipping quickly to the poem inscribed so long ago.

You hear a voice ring out from inside your head.

“Wait!”

